



All the COVID-19 ads are the same

A supercut of post coronavirus ads from numerous companies that seem to follow the same template. <https://digit.in/jun20-114>



Optimism in times of crisis

A look at how brands in India are putting out uplifting messages during the pandemic. <https://digit.in/jun20-115>



Credit: Allen.G / Shutterstock.com

BEYOND ADS

A look at the current promotional techniques being used, and how you can identify them

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Don't you miss the good old days when ads were ads and content was content? When the web was

as simple a place to differentiate as this magazine is? There is nothing wrong with advertising, of course, but it's nice when we, as readers, know the difference between something sponsored and something that isn't. For example, you will find all the advertising in this magazine generally clustered around the beginning pages. People pay premi-

ums to be amongst the first 20 pages of any print publication. Online, things work differently.

With social media, YouTube, search engine results, etc., ads took a different turn. You started getting sponsored results in searches and social posts and videos were boosted. And then there are famous people – an influencer on YouTube with 50,000 followers, or an A-list celeb with tens of millions of followers – who can be approached to promote things. Most celebs and influencers are somewhat honest about what's a paid promotion and what isn't. We're not even going to talk about traditional advertising here, because we're all used to that.



An example of product placement for FedEx in the movie Castaway

PRODUCT PLACEMENT

Product placements that are done in the everyday lives of influencers, celebrities, sports personalities, YouTube stars, and anyone with a large enough following (subscribers, fans, followers, whatever), wield some power, and this power is being monetised. Thankfully, studies have shown that for most influencers or celebs, paid or organic promotion doesn't really change things for followers – which means that the difference between a paid endorsement of a product vs the celeb actually using that product is negligible, but it certainly is more helpful for sales than the celebrity not using the product at all...

A product placement is very different from something being clearly sponsored, because it often isn't the focus of the article, video, or image. A celebrity who clicks a video while out jogging in their Nike running shoes, might just have chosen Nike running shoes because they're comfortable, or maybe they were paid to wear them. If you see the shoes in every shot or scene possible, then you can usually tell that it's paid content. Product placement in movies or series is also really common, and has been so for decades now.

TARGETED PROMOTIONS

Companies were, and are, trying to collect as much data as possible on you, because they want to make a profile about you that is sold as part of a larger group. So if you like Star Trek, and own an Apple phone, you belong to those two sets which may not have anything to do with each other. But companies can always find a correlation between various data sets, and arrive at a conclusion that says people who list Star Trek as their favourite show, and also own an iPhone are more likely to be interested in holiday bookings in the next 6 months than other comparable groups. Since Trekkies are nearing retirement, and owning an iPhone (in India) puts them in at least the middle class bracket, thus more free time and some money to blow = more time to